

The Fall of the House of Usher

Edgar Allan Poe · 1839

First published: Burton's Gentleman's Magazine, Sep 1839

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

AP edition (standards shown for this framework only)

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

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Cover: Jean-Honoré Fragonard, A Young Girl Reading (c. 1770). Public domain (Wikimedia Commons).

Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Unit test (eleven rigor versions) with answer keys and scoring guides
6. Final paper
7. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Works_of_the_Late_Edgar_Allan_Poe_(1850)/Volume_1/The_Fall_of_the_House_of_Usher (revision 14833569), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 10–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). The scaffolded-support track works from the full text with scaffolds. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 2 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Fall of the House of Usher suggest about decay of family and mind?
- What does The Fall of the House of Usher suggest about fear and the imagination?
- What does The Fall of the House of Usher suggest about the double?

Objectives

- Students will cite at least 2 quotations, with locations, to support each written claim about what the text says explicitly and implicitly (scored on the writing-prompt rubric).
- Students will trace one theme across at least 3 sections of the story in the final paper, earning at least 70 of 100 rubric points.
- Students will explain how characters, setting and point of view interact in at least 3 exit tickets, each meeting the claim-evidence-reasoning criteria.
- Students will determine the in-context meaning of taught vocabulary, scoring at least 80% on the vocabulary items of the story quizzes.
- Students will write an argument with a clear claim, reasons and relevant evidence, scoring at least 80% on the unit test's short-answer scoring guides.

Standards: AP

AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN

AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)

Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Scaffolded support through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* The Fall of the House of Usher	2 × 90 min (180 min)	*decay of family and mind* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to The Fall of the House of Usher

Objective: Students will explain, in a 3-sentence exit ticket, how one fact about Edgar Allan Poe's life or times connects to decay of family and mind in “The Fall of the House of Usher”, and will set up a reading journal with a prediction and a question for each of 3 themes (decay of family and mind, fear and the imagination, the double).

Standards: AP: see the unit standards

Author biography

Edgar Allan Poe was born in Boston on 19 January 1809 to touring actors; orphaned before he was three, he was raised in Richmond, Virginia, by the merchant John Allan, with whom he later quarrelled bitterly. He attended the University of Virginia, served in the U.S. Army and was dismissed from West Point, then lived by his pen as a poet, critic and magazine editor (the Southern Literary Messenger, Graham's Magazine) in Richmond, Philadelphia and New York. He married his young cousin Virginia Clemm, who died of tuberculosis in 1847. "The Raven" (1845) made him famous but never prosperous. He is credited with inventing the modern detective story ("The Murders in the Rue Morgue," 1841) and argued that a short story should create a single "unity of effect." He died in Baltimore on 7 October 1849; the cause of his death is unknown.

Historical and cultural context

Poe wrote within the Gothic tradition (crumbling mansions, ancient families, premature burial) popularized by English and German writers, but he turned its horrors inward: the decay of a house mirrors the decay of a mind. The 1830s were also a time of fascination with nervous illness and "hypochondriasis."

Publication and reception, then and now

First published in Burton's Gentleman's Magazine (Philadelphia) in September 1839, where Poe was an editor; collected in Tales of the Grotesque and Arabesque (1840).

Then: Contemporary reviewers praised its atmosphere; it was among the tales that built Poe's reputation abroad, especially in France through Charles Baudelaire's translations in the 1850s.

Now: It is considered a masterpiece of Gothic fiction and the clearest example of Poe's "unity of effect," often read psychologically (the house as the mind; Madeline as Roderick's double).

Overview (spoiler-free)

A narrator answers a desperate letter from his boyhood friend Roderick Usher and arrives at a gloomy mansion beside a dark lake. Roderick is ill with nervous terror, and his twin sister Madeline is wasting away.

Main themes

- decay of family and mind: house, family and mind fall together.
- fear and the imagination: Roderick fears fear itself.

- the double: twins, reflections, a house and its image in the lake.

Why it matters

The story shows how setting can carry psychology, a technique used in every horror film; it also opens conversations about isolation and mental illness.

Spoilers · teacher only

Madeline apparently dies and is entombed in a vault; days later, during a storm, she breaks out, falls on Roderick, and both die. The narrator flees as the house splits along its fissure and sinks into the tarn.

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Before we open The Fall of the House of Usher: Describe a place that made you feel uneasy. Which details created the feeling?
Prompt: Before we open The Fall of the House of Usher: Describe a place that made you feel uneasy. Which details created the feeling?

8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)
Key literary terms for the unit.
Gothic fiction; atmosphere; pathetic fallacy; doppelgänger (double); premature burial; tarn (a small mountain lake).

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture on the author, the historical context and the reception (read or adapt the script).
About the author. Edgar Allan Poe was born in Boston on 19 January 1809 to touring actors; orphaned before he was three, he was raised in Richmond, Virginia, by the merchant John Allan, with whom he later quarrelled bitterly. He attended the University of Virginia, served in the U.S. Army and was dismissed from West Point, then lived by his pen as a poet, critic and magazine editor (the Southern Literary Messenger, Graham's Magazine) in Richmond, Philadelphia and New York. He married his young cousin Virginia Clemm, who died of tuberculosis in 1847. "The Raven" (1845) made him famous but never prosperous. He is credited with inventing the modern detective story ("The Murders in the Rue Morgue," 1841) and argued that a short story should create a single "unity of effect." He died in Baltimore on 7 October 1849; the cause of his death is unknown. The world of the book. Poe wrote within the Gothic tradition (crumbling mansions, ancient families, premature burial) popularized by English and German writers, but he turned its horrors inward: the decay of a house mirrors the decay of a mind. The 1830s were also a time of fascination with nervous illness and "hypochondriasis." Publication and reception. First published in Burton's Gentleman's Magazine (Philadelphia) in September 1839, where Poe was an editor; collected in Tales of the Grotesque and Arabesque (1840). Then: Contemporary reviewers praised its atmosphere; it was among the tales that built Poe's reputation abroad, especially in France through Charles Baudelaire's translations in the 1850s. Now: It is considered a masterpiece of Gothic fiction and the clearest example of Poe's "unity of effect," often read psychologically (the house as the mind; Madeline as Roderick's double).

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)
Model a close reading of one passage using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "During the whole of a dull, dark, and soundless day in the autumn of the year" slowly and put it in my own words: The narrator rides alone through a whole dull, dark, soundless autumn day. Next, craft. I notice three heavy adjectives in a row, all with low, flat sounds. The strongest word is "soundless": it removes even noise, so the world feels dead before he reaches the house. Then, effect. How does the opening phrase create the story's mood? My answer: Poe builds gloom before anything happens, which is his "single effect": the reader is already uneasy at the first sentence.

> *During the whole of a dull, dark, and soundless day in the autumn of the year (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 4)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "During the whole of a dull, dark, and soundless day in the autumn of the year" slowly and put it in my own words: The narrator rides alone through a whole dull, dark, soundless autumn day. Next, craft. I notice three heavy adjectives in a row, all with low, flat sounds. The strongest word is "soundless": it removes even noise, so the world feels dead before he reaches the house. Then, effect. How does the opening phrase create the story's mood? My answer: Poe builds gloom before anything happens, which is his "single effect": the reader is already uneasy at the first sentence.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)
Read the spoiler-free overview together and name the themes to track.
What the book is about (no spoilers): A narrator answers a desperate letter from his boyhood friend Roderick Usher and arrives at a gloomy mansion beside a dark lake. Roderick is ill with nervous terror, and his twin sister Madeline is wasting away. Themes to track: decay of family and mind: house, family and mind fall together. fear and the imagination: Roderick fears fear itself. the double: twins, reflections, a house and its image in the lake.

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme, with a prediction and a question (example given).
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question. Page: decay of family and mind. Prediction: the cracked, gloomy house will mirror the health of the Usher family. Question: is the narrator's fear caused by the house, by Roderick, or by his own imagination?
Task: Set up a reading journal for The Fall of the House of Usher: one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.
Exemplar: Page: decay of family and mind. Prediction: the cracked, gloomy house will mirror the health of the Usher family. Question: is the narrator's fear caused by the house, by Roderick, or by his own imagination?

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Whole-class discussion: why the book is still taught.
Why does The Fall of the House of Usher still matter? The story shows how setting can carry psychology, a technique used in every horror film; it also opens conversations about isolation and mental illness.
Anchor question: Why might The Fall of the House of Usher still be taught today?
Facilitation: The story shows how setting can carry psychology, a technique used in every horror film; it also opens conversations about isolation and mental illness.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)

Exit ticket on the author and context (answer given).

Poe's mother, the actress Eliza Poe, died of tuberculosis in Richmond in 1811, when he was two, and he published "Usher" in Burton's Gentleman's Magazine in 1839. Name one way this background could shape a story about a decaying family. Answer: Accept answers such as: fear of losing loved ones, as Poe lost his mother; obsession with illness and death; the image of the Usher family and its house slowly dying together.

Exit ticket: Poe's mother, the actress Eliza Poe, died of tuberculosis in Richmond in 1811, when he was two, and he published "Usher" in Burton's Gentleman's Magazine in 1839. Name one way this background could shape a story about a decaying family.

Answer: Accept answers such as: fear of losing loved ones, as Poe lost his mother; obsession with illness and death; the image of the Usher family and its house slowly dying together.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)

Preview the first reading.

Tomorrow we begin reading: The Fall of the House of Usher.

Teacher notes · sources: Poe Museum, Richmond, "Poe's Life" (https://poemuseum.org/poes-life/); Edgar Allan Poe Society of Baltimore (texts and publication history) (https://www.eapoe.org/); Poe Society of Baltimore, "The Fall of the House of Usher" (https://www.eapoe.org/works/tales/usherb.htm)

Lesson 2: The Fall of the House of Usher

Focus: a family and a house collapsing together

Objective: Students will analyze how setting develops in “The Fall of the House of Usher” by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: AP: see the unit standards

Content note (premature burial, gothic dread, alcohol or drugs (mentioned)): Sensitive content: Premature burial; gothic dread. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail. This section mentions drinking or a drug (“…erly than to the after-dream of the reveller upon opium—the bitter lapse into every-day life—th…”). Treat it as period custom or plot detail; name it plainly and don't glamorize it.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes premature burial; gothic dread.
Suggested language: “Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?”

Teacher only · spoilers

The narrator answers a letter from his boyhood friend Roderick Usher and visits the gloomy Usher mansion, which has a faint crack running down its front. Roderick suffers from acute senses and dread; his twin Madeline wastes away and is entombed in a vault, apparently dead. Days later, during a storm, she bursts out of her tomb and falls dead on her brother, who dies of terror. The narrator flees as the house splits along the crack and sinks into the tarn.

Background: Published in 1839, the story belongs to the gothic tradition of crumbling mansions and family curses. 'House' means both the building and the family line.

Significance: Its opening paragraph is a famous study in creating mood; the double meaning of 'House' ties setting to theme.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Think of a place that made you uneasy. What details created that feeling? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to fear and the imagination because.... Content note before we start: Heads-up: this story includes premature burial; gothic dread.
Prompt: Think of a place that made you uneasy. What details created that feeling?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to fear and the imagination because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: unmingled — pure; not mixed with anything else; equivocal — open to two or more interpretations; or of uncertain nature or significance; or (often) intended to mislead; despaired — abandon hope; give up hope; lose heart; trepidation — a feeling of alarm or dread; profuse — produced or growing in extreme abundance. "unmingled": Origin: an English formation from un- + mingled. "trepidation": Origin: Latin trepidātiō.
Words: unmingled: pure; not mixed with anything else · equivocal: open to two or more interpretations; or of uncertain nature or significance; or (often) intended to mislead · despaired: abandon hope; give up hope; lose heart · trepidation: a feeling of alarm or dread · profuse: produced or growing in extreme abundance

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Published in 1839, the story belongs to the gothic tradition of crumbling mansions and family curses. 'House' means both the building and the family line. Its opening paragraph is a famous study in creating mood; the double meaning of 'House' ties setting to theme. Setting: The house is described like a face: "vacant eye-like windows," decayed stones, a "barely perceptible fissure" running from roof to water. The setting is the story's main character. Imagery: Sound and light are muffled and dim; inside, Roderick's paintings and music (and the poem "The Haunted Palace") repeat the story's own images. Symbolism: The House of Usher means both the building and the family line; when one falls, so does the other. Watch for the fissure: the hairline crack that splits the house at the end: a hidden flaw in the family and in Roderick's mind.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "I feel that the period will sooner or later arrive when I must abandon life and reason together, in some struggle with the grim..." slowly and put it in my own words: Roderick tells the narrator he expects to give up his life and his sanity in a struggle with Fear itself. Next, craft. I notice "Fear" is capitalized and called a "phantasm," a ghostly figure he expects to fight. The strongest word is "phantasm": it means an illusion or ghost, so his enemy is in his own mind. Then, effect. Why does Roderick fear he will lose life and reason together? My answer: He knows his terror is consuming him; the line predicts that the collapse of his mind and the collapse of the house will happen together.

> *I feel that the period will sooner or later arrive when I must abandon life and reason together, in some struggle with the grim phantasm, Fear* *(The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 14)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "I feel that the period will sooner or later arrive when I must abandon life and reason together, in some struggle with the grim…" slowly and put it in my own words: Roderick tells the narrator he expects to give up his life and his sanity in a struggle with Fear itself. Next, craft. I notice "Fear" is capitalized and called a "phantasm," a ghostly figure he expects to fight. The strongest word is "phantasm": it means an illusion or ghost, so his enemy is in his own mind. Then, effect. Why does Roderick fear he will lose life and reason together? My answer: He knows his terror is consuming him; the line predicts that the collapse of his mind and the collapse of the house will happen together.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: The fissure is small at first, as Roderick's illness is hidden; it foreshadows the ending. Expected link: decay of family and mind. Ask: How does this line connect to fear and the imagination? Expected: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic. (Foreshadowing the collapse.)

> *a barely perceptible fissure, which, extending from the roof of the building in front, made its way down the wall in a zigzag direction (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 8)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: The fissure is small at first, as Roderick's illness is hidden; it foreshadows the ending. Expected link: decay of family and mind.
Ask: How does this line connect to fear and the imagination?
Expected answer: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic. (Foreshadowing the collapse.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the story for setting, imagery (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about a family and a house collapsing together? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Fall of the House of Usher develops the idea of a family and a house collapsing together. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of setting and imagery shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his. When the text says “a barely perceptible fissure, which, extending from the roof of the building in front, made its way down the wall in a zigzag direction” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 8), it shows this directly. The narrator notices "a barely perceptible fissure" from roof to ground, and Roderick foresees the day he "must abandon life and reason together"; at the end the fissure widens and house and mind fall at once.
Task: Annotate the story for setting, imagery (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about a family and a house collapsing together? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Fall of the House of Usher develops the idea of a family and a house collapsing together. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of setting and imagery shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his. When the text says “a barely perceptible fissure, which, extending from the roof of the building in front, made its way down the wall in a zigzag direction” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 8), it shows this directly. The narrator notices "a barely perceptible fissure" from roof to ground, and Roderick foresees the day he "must abandon life and reason together"; at the end the fissure widens and house and mind fall at once.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: Think of a place that made you uneasy. What details created that feeling? Ask: is Madeline really alive, or is the ending the narrator's (or Roderick's) hallucination? Use the storm passage.
Anchor question: Think of a place that made you uneasy. What details created that feeling?
Facilitation: Ask: is Madeline really alive, or is the ending the narrator's (or Roderick's) hallucination? Use the storm passage.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Story quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about a family and a house collapsing together? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his. (“a barely perceptible fissure, which, extending from the roof of the building in front, made its way down the wall in a zigzag direction”, The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 8). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about a family and a house collapsing together? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his. (“a barely perceptible fissure, which, extending from the roof of the building in front, made its way down the wall in a zigzag direction”, The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 8). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how setting shapes a family and a house collapsing together. Key takeaway: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Setting:** The house is described like a face: "vacant eye-like windows," decayed stones, a "barely perceptible fissure" running from roof to water. The setting is the story's main character.
- **Imagery:** Sound and light are muffled and dim; inside, Roderick's paintings and music (and the poem "The Haunted Palace") repeat the story's own images.
- **Symbolism:** The House of Usher means both the building and the family line; when one falls, so does the other.

Themes and how they develop

- **fear and the imagination:** Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic.

Symbols and motifs

- **the fissure:** the hairline crack that splits the house at the end: a hidden flaw in the family and in Roderick's mind.

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "a barely perceptible fissure, which, extending from the roof of the building in front, made its way down the wall in a zigzag direction" (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 8) Foreshadowing the collapse.
- "I feel that the period will sooner or later arrive when I must abandon life and reason together, in some struggle with the grim phantasm, Fear" (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 14) Roderick's prophecy.
- "We have put her living in the tomb" (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 92) Roderick's confession during the storm.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his.
Evidence: "a barely perceptible fissure, which, extending from the roof of the building in front, made its way down the wall in a zigzag direction" (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 8)
Reasoning: The narrator notices "a barely perceptible fissure" from roof to ground, and Roderick foresees the day he "must abandon life and reason together"; at the end the fissure widens and house and mind fall at once.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
unmingled (adjective)	pure; not mixed with anything else	*I regarded her with an utter astonishment not unmingled with dread—and yet I found it impossible to account for such feelings.*	"unmingled": Origin: an English formation from un- + mingled. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/unmingled#Etymology)
equivocal (adjective)	open to two or more interpretations; or of uncertain nature or significance; or (often) intended to mislead	*I learned, moreover, at intervals, and through broken and equivocal hints, another singular feature of his mental condition.*	
despaired (verb)	abandon hope; give up hope; lose heart	*It was, he said, a constitutional and a family evil, and one for which he despaired to find a remedy—a mere nervous affection, he immediately added, which would undoubtedly soon pass off.*	
trepidation (noun)	a feeling of alarm or dread	*He accosted me with trepidation and passed on.*	"trepidation": Origin: Latin trepidātiō. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://

			en.wiktionary.org/wiki/trepidation#Etymology)
profuse (adjective)	produced or growing in extreme abundance	*The general furniture was profuse, comfortless, antique, and tattered.*	
perusal (noun)	a careful reading	*His chief delight, however, was found in the perusal of an exceedingly rare and curious book in quarto Gothic—the manual of a forgotten church—the Vigiliae Mortuorum secundum Chorum Ecclesiae Maguntinae.*	
overspread (verb)	spread across or over	*Minute fungi overspread the whole exterior, hanging in a fine tangled web-work from the eaves.*	"overspread": Origin: an English formation from over- + spread. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/overspread#Etymology)
accosted (verb)	approached and spoken to	*He accosted me with trepidation and passed on.*	"accosted": Origin of "accost": Middle French accoster; earlier Old French acoster ("to stand beside"). (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/accost#Etymology)
narrowly (adverb)	closely; carefully	*Shaking off from my spirit what must have been a dream, I scanned more narrowly the real aspect of the building.*	"narrowly": Origin: an English formation from narrow + -ly. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/narrowly#Etymology)
abhorrence (noun)	hate coupled with disgust	*I have, indeed, no abhorrence of danger, except in its absolute effect—in terror.*	

Discussion questions

1. Think of a place that made you uneasy. What details created that feeling?
2. Where does setting appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with decay of family and mind?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. Why does the narrator visit the House of Usher? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · AP: unit standards] Look for: Roderick wrote asking for his company
2. What flaw does the narrator notice in the house's front? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP: unit standards] Look for: A barely visible crack running down the wall
3. Who is Madeline? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · AP: unit standards] Look for: Roderick's twin sister
4. What happens to Madeline that turns out to be terrible? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP: unit standards] Look for: She is entombed while still alive
5. What happens to the house at the end? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · AP: unit standards] Look for: It splits apart and sinks into the tarn
6. Retell the three most important events of "The Fall of the House of Usher" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP: unit standards] Look for: The narrator answers a letter from his boyhood friend Roderick Usher and visits the gloomy Usher mansion, which has a faint crack running down its front. Roderick suffers from acute senses and dread; his twin Madeline wastes away and is entombed in a vault, apparently dead. Days later, during a storm, she bursts out of her tomb and falls dead on her brother, who dies of terror. The narrator flees…
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in "The Fall of the House of Usher"? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · AP: unit standards] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does "The Fall of the House of Usher" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP: unit standards] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: "I regarded her with an utter astonishment not unmingled with dread—and yet I found it impossible to account for such feelings." What does "unmingled" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP: unit standards] Look for: unmingled: pure; not mixed with anything else.
10. Reread: "I learned, moreover, at intervals, and through broken and equivocal hints, another singular feature of his mental condition." What does "equivocal" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · AP: unit standards] Look for: equivocal: open to two or more interpretations; or of uncertain nature or significance; or (often) intended to mislead.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does "The Fall of the House of Usher" suggest about a family and a house collapsing together? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: Its opening paragraph is a famous study in creating mood; the double meaning of 'House' ties setting to theme.
2. Find one example of setting in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.SET] Look for: Look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling.
3. How does the imagery in this story shape what we understand about a family and a house collapsing together? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.FIG] Look for: Look for sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his. Useful evidence: "a barely perceptible fissure, which, extending from the roof of the building in front, made its way down the wall in a zigzag direction" (The Fall of the House of Usher,

paragraph 8): Foreshadowing the collapse. On imagery: Sound and light are muffled and dim; inside, Roderick's paintings and music (and the poem "The Haunted Palace") repeat the story's own images. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. In the passage that begins “The room in which I found myself was very large and lofty.”, why might Poe have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.FIG] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Fall of the House of Usher”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.STR] Look for: The narrator answers a letter from his boyhood friend Roderick Usher and visits the gloomy Usher mansion, which has a faint crack running down its front. Roderick suffers from acute senses and dread; his twin Madeline wastes away and is entombed in a vault, apparently dead. Days later, during a…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Fall of the House of Usher” set up that the rest of The Fall of the House of Usher will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.STR] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his. Useful evidence: “I feel that the period will sooner or later arrive when I must abandon life and reason together, in some struggle with the grim phantasm, Fear” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 14): Roderick's prophecy. Theme link: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.CHR] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his. Useful evidence: “We have put her living in the tomb” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 92): Roderick's confession during the storm. Theme link: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “Think of a place that made you uneasy. What details created that feeling?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does symbolism appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with decay of family and mind? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.FIG] Look for: Look for objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his. Useful evidence: “a barely perceptible fissure, which, extending from the roof of the building in front, made its way down the wall in a zigzag direction” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 8): Foreshadowing the collapse. On symbolism: The House of Usher means both the building and the family line; when one falls, so does the other. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Background: Published in 1839, the story belongs to the gothic tradition of crumbling mansions and family curses. 'House' means both the building and the family line. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.SET] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his. Useful evidence: “I feel that the period will sooner or later arrive when I must abandon life and reason together, in some struggle with the grim phantasm, Fear” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 14): Roderick's prophecy. On setting: The house is described like a face: "vacant eye-like windows," decayed stones, a "barely perceptible fissure" running from roof to water. The setting is the story's main character. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “Its opening paragraph is a famous study in creating mood; the double meaning of 'House' ties setting to theme.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his. Useful evidence: “We have put her living in the tomb” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 92): Roderick's confession during the storm. Theme link: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his. Useful evidence: “a barely perceptible fissure, which, extending from the roof of the building in front, made its way down the wall in a zigzag direction” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 8): Foreshadowing the collapse. Theme link: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Rewrite one moment of “The Fall of the House of Usher” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about a family and a house collapsing together? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.NAR] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his. Useful evidence: “I feel that the period will sooner or later arrive when I must abandon life and reason together, in some struggle with the grim phantasm, Fear” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 14): Roderick's prophecy. Theme link: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. Write three questions of your own about “The Fall of the House of Usher”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · AP-

LIT.LAN] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his. Useful evidence: “We have put her living in the tomb” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 92): Roderick's confession during the storm. Theme link: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Connect this story to fear and the imagination: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Poe need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his. Useful evidence: “a barely perceptible fissure, which, extending from the roof of the building in front, made its way down the wall in a zigzag direction” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 8): Foreshadowing the collapse. Theme link: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Is the setting in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.SET] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his. Useful evidence: “I feel that the period will sooner or later arrive when I must abandon life and reason together, in some struggle with the grim phantasm, Fear” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 14): Roderick's prophecy. On setting: The house is described like a face: "vacant eye-like windows," decayed stones, a "barely perceptible fissure" running from roof to water. The setting is the story's main character. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Compare how “The Fall of the House of Usher” treats a family and a house collapsing together with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Fall of the House of Usher see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his. Useful evidence: “We have put her living in the tomb” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 92): Roderick's confession during the storm. Theme link: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. As the final story, does this ending resolve decay of family and mind? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN, AP-LIT.STR] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his. Useful evidence: “a barely perceptible fissure, which, extending from the roof of the building in front, made its way down the wall in a zigzag direction” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 8): Foreshadowing the collapse. Theme link: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic. Credit any

position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about a family and a house collapsing together? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his. Useful evidence: “I feel that the period will sooner or later arrive when I must abandon life and reason together, in some struggle with the grim phantasm, Fear” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 14): Roderick's prophecy. Theme link: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. What question would you most like to ask Edgar Allan Poe about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · AP-LIT.LAN] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his. Useful evidence: “We have put her living in the tomb” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 92): Roderick's confession during the storm. Theme link: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Setting:** look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Imagery**: sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create
- Also notice **Symbolism**: objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “His chief delight, however, was found in the _____ of an exceedingly rare and curious book in quarto Gothic—the manual of a forgotten church—the Vigiliae Mortuorum secundum Chorum Ecclesiae Maguntinae.” Word bank: despaired, perusal, unmingled, equivocal
   Key: perusal
2. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “The general furniture was _____, comfortless, antique, and tattered.” Word bank: unmingled, equivocal, despaired, profuse
   Key: profuse
3. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What happens to the house at the end?
   A. It burns down
   B. The narrator inherits it
   C. It splits apart and sinks into the tarn
   D. It is sold

Key: C (It splits apart and sinks into the tarn)

4. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 8: “a barely _____ fissure, which, extending from the roof of the building in front, made its way down the wall in a zigzag direction”

   Key: perceptible

5. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who is Madeline?

   A. The housekeeper
   B. Roderick's twin sister
   C. Roderick's wife
   D. The narrator's cousin

   Key: B (Roderick's twin sister)

6. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “He _____ me with trepidation and passed on.” Word bank: unmingled, accosted, despaired, equivocal

   Key: accosted

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Why does the narrator visit the House of Usher?

   A. He is lost in a storm
   B. Roderick wrote asking for his company
   C. He wants to buy it
   D. He is a doctor called to Madeline

   Key: B (Roderick wrote asking for his company)

8. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What happens to Madeline that turns out to be terrible?

   A. She is entombed while still alive
   B. She runs away
   C. She burns the house
   D. She marries the narrator

   Key: A (She is entombed while still alive)

9. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What flaw does the narrator notice in the house's front?

   A. A barely visible crack running down the wall
   B. A missing door
   C. A broken window
   D. A fallen tower

   Key: A (A barely visible crack running down the wall)

10. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 92: “We have put her _____ in the tomb”

    Key: living

11. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Minute fungi _____ the whole exterior, hanging in a fine tangled web-work from the eaves.” Word bank: overspread, unmingled, despaired, equivocal

    Key: overspread

12. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “a barely perceptible fissure, which, extending from the roof of the building in front, made its way down the wall in a zigzag direction” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 8).
    Sample answer: The narrator notices "a barely perceptible fissure" from roof to ground, and Roderick foresees the day he "must abandon life and reason together"; at the end the fissure widens and house and mind fall at once.
13. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “We have put her living in the tomb” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 92). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
    Sample answer: Roderick's confession during the storm.
14. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
    Sample answer: The narrator notices "a barely perceptible fissure" from roof to ground, and Roderick foresees the day he "must abandon life and reason together"; at the end the fissure widens and house and mind fall at once.
15. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how fear and the imagination develops from an earlier story to “The Fall of the House of Usher”. Use one quotation from each.
    Sample answer: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic.
16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “I feel that the period will sooner or later arrive when I must abandon life and reason together, in some struggle with the grim phantasm, Fear” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 14) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Roderick's prophecy.
17. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 20? “Certain accessory points of the design served well to convey the idea that this _____ lay at an exceeding depth below the surface of the earth.”

    A. inexplicable
    B. exaggeration
    C. excavation
    D. unconscious

    Key: C (excavation)
18. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from paragraph 12: “For something of this nature I had indeed been prepared, no less by his letter, than by _____ of certain boyish traits, and by conclusions deduced from his peculiar physical conformation and temperament.” Word bank: reminiscences, objectless, impromptus, unconscious
    Key: reminiscences
19. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from paragraph 74: “He roamed from chamber to chamber with hurried, unequal, and _____ step.” Word bank: objectless, impromptus, emaciated, reminiscences
    Key: objectless
20. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from paragraph 4: “I know not how it was—but, with the first glimpse of the building, a sense of _____ gloom pervaded my spirit.” Word bank: insufferable, persuasion,

unconscious, excavation

Key: insufferable

21. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 4? “It was a mystery all _____; nor could I grapple with the shadowy fancies that crowded upon me as I pondered.”

    A. experiment
    B. insoluble
    C. perceiving
    D. proceeding

    Key: B (insoluble)

22. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 74? “At times, again, I was obliged to resolve all into the mere _____ vagaries of madness, for I beheld him gazing upon vacancy for long hours, in an attitude of the profoundest attention, as if listening to some imaginary sound.”

    A. emaciated
    B. proceeding
    C. excavation
    D. inexplicable

    Key: D (inexplicable)

23. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which of these passages comes earliest in the story?

    A. “It was a mystery all insoluble; nor could I grapple with the shadowy fancies that crowded upon me as I pondered.”
    B. “I know not how it was—but, with the first glimpse of the building, a sense of insufferable gloom pervaded my spirit.”
    C. “Ihave said that the sole effect of my somewhat childish experiment—that of looking down within the tarn—had been to deepen the first…”
    D. “A letter, however, had lately reached me in a distant part of the country—a letter from him—which, in its wildly importunate nature, had…”

    Key: B (“I know not how it was—but, with the first glimpse of the building, a sense of insufferable gloom pervaded my spirit.”)

24. [short · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage from paragraph 4 reveal about the character or situation? “It was a mystery all insoluble; nor could I grapple with the shadowy fancies that crowded upon me as I pondered.” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: A response that accurately paraphrases the passage (paragraph 4), cites a specific word or detail from it, and explains its significance.

25. [short · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage from paragraph 79 reveal about the character or situation? “Let us close this casement;—the air is chilling and dangerous to your frame.” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: A response that accurately paraphrases the passage (paragraph 79), cites a specific word or detail from it, and explains its significance.

26. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 73 shapes its tone: “Having deposited our mournful burden upon tressels within this region of horror, we partially turned aside the yet unscrewed lid of the coffin, and looked upon the face of the tenant.” Pick two words and

explain their effect.

Sample answer: A response that accurately paraphrases the passage (paragraph 73), cites a specific word or detail from it, and explains its significance.

27. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 91 shapes its tone: “But, as I placed my hand upon his shoulder, there came a strong shudder over his whole person; a sickly smile quivered about his lips; and I saw that he spoke in a low, hurried, and gibbering murmur, as if unconscious of my presence.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: A response that accurately paraphrases the passage (paragraph 91), cites a specific word or detail from it, and explains its significance.

28. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “a barely perceptible fissure, which, extending from the roof of the building in front, made its way down the wall in a zigzag direction” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 8) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Foreshadowing the collapse.

29. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from paragraph 81: “Here, it will be _____, the words of the narrative run thus:” Word bank: remembered, insoluble, narrative, improvisations

    Key: remembered

30. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from paragraph 11: “We sat down; and for some _____, while he spoke not, I gazed upon him with a feeling half of pity, half of awe.” Word bank: perceiving, moments, proceeding, insoluble

    Key: moments

31. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 93? “There was blood upon her white robes, and the evidence of some bitter struggle upon every portion of her _____ frame.”

    A. proceeding
    B. emaciated
    C. persuasion
    D. deposited

    Key: B (emaciated)

32. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from paragraph 75: “I struggled to reason off the _____ which had dominion over me.” Word bank: nervousness, excavation, impromptus, objectless

    Key: nervousness

33. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 73? “Having _____ our mournful burden upon tressels within this region of horror, we partially turned aside the yet unscrewed lid of the coffin, and looked upon the face of the tenant.”

    A. deposited
    B. impromptus
    C. nervousness
    D. experiment

    Key: A (deposited)

34. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from paragraph 91: “But, as I placed my hand upon his shoulder, there came a strong shudder over his whole person; a sickly smile quivered about his lips; and I saw that he spoke in a low, hurried, and gibbering murmur, as if _____ of my presence.” Word bank: deposited,

impromptus, emaciated, unconscious

Key: unconscious

35. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Connect this passage from paragraph 18 to the story's treatment of the double: "We painted and read together; or I listened, as if in a dream, to the wild improvisations of his speaking guitar." Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: A response that accurately paraphrases the passage (paragraph 18), cites a specific word or detail from it, and explains its significance for the double.

36. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from paragraph 5: "A letter, however, had lately reached me in a distant part of the country—a letter from him—which, in its wildly _____ nature, had admitted of no other than a personal reply." Word bank: emaciated, importunate, persuasion, exaggeration

    Key: importunate

37. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 11 shapes its tone: "We sat down; and for some moments, while he spoke not, I gazed upon him with a feeling half of pity, half of awe." Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: A response that accurately paraphrases the passage (paragraph 11), cites a specific word or detail from it, and explains its significance.

38. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Connect this passage from paragraph 75 to the story's treatment of the double: "I struggled to reason off the nervousness which had dominion over me." Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: A response that accurately paraphrases the passage (paragraph 75), cites a specific word or detail from it, and explains its significance for the double.

39. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? "We have put her living in the tomb" (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 92)

    A. The question that drives the whole story, repeated for emphasis.

    B. The opening question: a world of storm and repetition.

    C. Roderick's confession during the storm.

    D. The turn from ambition to revulsion in one sentence.

    Key: C (Roderick's confession during the storm.)

40. [short · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage from paragraph 21 reveal about the character or situation? "But the fervid facility of his impromptus could not be so accounted for." Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: A response that accurately paraphrases the passage (paragraph 21), cites a specific word or detail from it, and explains its significance.

41. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of "The Fall of the House of Usher"?

    A. Waking into a changed nation

    B. The closing of the frontier

    C. What fifteen years of solitude teach

    D. A family and a house collapsing together

    Key: D (A family and a house collapsing together)

42. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Fall of the House of Usher”? Sound and light are muffled and dim; inside, Roderick's paintings and music (and the poem "The Haunted Palace") repeat the story's own images.

    A. Imagery

    B. Diction / vocabulary

    C. Foreshadowing

    D. Symbolism

    Key: A (Imagery)

43. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 89? “Having rapidly taken notice of all this, I resumed the _____ of Sir Launcelot, which thus proceeded:”

    A. emaciated

    B. objectless

    C. narrative

    D. proceeding

    Key: C (narrative)

44. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “I feel that the period will sooner or later arrive when I must abandon life and reason together, in some struggle with the grim phantasm, Fear” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 14) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Roderick's prophecy.

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 11, inference 0, analysis 2, synthesis 3
HS Freshman	17, 18, 19, 20, 5, 1, 21, 22, 23, 23, 24, 25, 13, 26, 27, 28	recall 8, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	2, 1, 29, 30, 31, 32, 22, 23, 23, 25, 24, 12, 26, 13, 14, 15	recall 7, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	6, 32, 22, 10, 31, 33, 34, 25, 24, 23, 23, 12, 13, 26, 15, 35	recall 7, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Senior	36, 3, 10, 7, 2, 1, 24, 23, 23, 25, 13, 12, 26, 35, 15, 14	recall 6, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 3
AP	7, 10, 2, 9, 23, 23, 24, 37, 13, 26, 27, 35, 28, 38, 15, 16	recall 4, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 5
College Freshman	1, 7, 4, 23, 39, 40, 41, 25, 23, 37, 26, 28, 14, 38, 16, 35	recall 3, inference 6, analysis 2, synthesis 5
College Sophomore	2, 8, 1, 23, 23, 24, 40, 42, 12, 26, 27, 37, 13, 35, 14, 38	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 6, synthesis 3
College Junior	11, 17, 2, 23, 23, 40, 13, 27, 26, 42, 37, 14, 16, 28, 35, 38	recall 3, inference 3, analysis 5, synthesis 5
College Senior	2, 20, 43, 23, 25, 39, 23, 24, 26, 12, 42, 27, 37, 14, 35, 38	recall 3, inference 5, analysis 5, synthesis 3
Graduate / PhD	1, 2, 7, 23, 25, 44, 23, 24, 39, 26, 27, 37, 35, 15, 38, 14	recall 3, inference 6, analysis 3, synthesis 4

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; AP: see unit standards): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “The Fall of the House of Usher,” how does Poe show a family and a house collapsing together? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the setting you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; AP: see unit standards): In The Fall of the House of Usher, how does Poe develop the idea of a family and a house collapsing together? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the setting in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; AP: see unit standards): Analyze how The Fall of the House of Usher develops the idea of a family and a house collapsing together. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of setting and imagery shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; AP: see unit standards): Analyze how the structure of The Fall of the House of Usher (where it begins, turns and ends) and its setting shape the reader's understanding of a family and a house collapsing together. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; AP: see unit standards): Two readers disagree about what The Fall of the House of Usher suggests about a family and a house collapsing together. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's setting and imagery), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.LAN): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Edgar Allan Poe uses setting in The Fall of the House of Usher to complicate the reader's understanding of a family and a house collapsing together. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; AP: see unit standards): Situate The Fall of the House of Usher within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of a family and a house collapsing together responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; AP: see unit standards): Read The Fall of the House of Usher alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of a family and a house collapsing together follows or bends those conventions, using the setting as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; AP: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Fall of the House of Usher and its treatment of a family and a house collapsing together. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's setting and imagery, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; AP: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads The Fall of the House of Usher as evidence for a larger claim about a family and a house collapsing together in The Fall of the House of Usher. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; AP: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads The Fall of the House of Usher as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of a family and a house collapsing together. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Fall of the House of Usher.

SAT-style questions

1. *It was, he said, a constitutional and a family evil, and one for which he despaired to find a remedy—a mere nervous affection, he immediately added, which would undoubtedly soon pass off.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “despaired” most nearly mean?

   A. abandon hope; give up hope; lose heart

   B. approached and spoken to

   C. closely; carefully

   D. hate coupled with disgust

2. *The room in which I found myself was very large and lofty. The windows were long, narrow, and pointed, and at so vast a distance from the black oaken floor as to be altogether inaccessible from within. Feeble gleams of encrimsoned light made their way through the trellissed panes, and served to render sufficiently distinct the more prominent objects around; the eye, however, struggled in vain to reach the remoter angles of the chamber, or the recesses of the vaulted and fretted ceiling. Dark draperies hung upon the walls. The general furniture was profuse, comfortless, antique, and tattered. Many books and musical instruments lay scattered about, but failed to give any vitality to the scene. I felt that I breathed an atmosphere of sorrow. An air of stern, deep, and irredeemable gloom hung over and pervaded all.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “The Fall of the House of Usher”?

   A. A boy's romantic quest ending in disillusion

   B. A family and a house collapsing together

   C. Superstition used against a credulous man

   D. A reversal that punishes a change of heart

SAT key: 1. A (abandon hope; give up hope; lose heart); 2. B (A family and a house collapsing together)

Unit test

The Fall of the House of Usher: end test · 90 minutes · 18 questions per rigor version (multiple choice, fill in the blank, short answer). The class rigor level picks the version; student auto-adjust applies.

Short-answer scoring guides

Scaffolded support and HS Freshman (2 points): correct answer in a complete sentence with a detail from the text. HS Sophomore to HS Senior (3 points): claim, one accurate quotation, one sentence of explanation. AP to College Sophomore (4 points): precise claim, two embedded quotations, commentary on word choice or structure, link to theme. College Junior to Graduate (5 points): nuanced thesis, close reading of two passages, synthesis across sections, a competing reading answered. Each item lists a sample answer; partial credit is described in the app.

Unit test: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from paragraph 12: “For something of this nature I had indeed been prepared, no less by his letter, than by _____ of certain boyish traits, and by conclusions deduced from his peculiar physical conformation and temperament.” Word bank: reminiscences, objectless, impromptus, unconscious

   Key: reminiscences

2. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 76? “His countenance was, as usual, _____ wan—but, moreover, there was a species of mad hilarity in his eyes—an evidently restrained hysteria in his whole demeanor.”

   A. cadaverously
   B. dangerous
   C. inexplicable
   D. unconscious

   Key: A (cadaverously)

3. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 74? “At times, again, I was obliged to resolve all into the mere _____ vagaries of madness, for I beheld him gazing upon vacancy for long hours, in an attitude of the profoundest attention, as if listening to some imaginary sound.”

   A. emaciated
   B. proceeding
   C. excavation
   D. inexplicable

   Key: D (inexplicable)

4. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 4? “It was a mystery all _____; nor could I grapple with the shadowy fancies that crowded upon me as I pondered.”

   A. experiment
   B. insoluble
   C. perceiving
   D. proceeding

Key: B (insoluble)

5. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from paragraph 91: “But, as I placed my hand upon his shoulder, there came a strong shudder over his whole person; a sickly smile quivered about his lips; and I saw that he spoke in a low, hurried, and gibbering murmur, as if _____ of my presence.” Word bank: deposited, impromptus, emaciated, unconscious

   Key: unconscious

6. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 93? “There was blood upon her white robes, and the evidence of some bitter struggle upon every portion of her _____ frame.”

   A. proceeding
   B. emaciated
   C. persuasion
   D. deposited

   Key: B (emaciated)

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 7? “Ihave said that the sole effect of my somewhat childish _____—that of looking down within the tarn—had been to deepen the first singular impression.”

   A. inexplicable
   B. remembered
   C. objectless
   D. experiment

   Key: D (experiment)

8. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 11? “And now in the mere _____ of the prevailing character of these features, and of the expression they were wont to convey, lay so much of change that I doubted to whom I spoke.”

   A. exaggeration
   B. improvisations
   C. narrative
   D. inexplicable

   Key: A (exaggeration)

9. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from paragraph 71: “The worldly reason, however, assigned for this singular _____, was one which I did not feel at liberty to dispute.” Word bank: impromptus, exaggeration, proceeding, persuasion

   Key: proceeding

10. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 69? “I lack words to express the full extent, or the earnest abandon of his _____.”

    A. persuasion
    B. excavation
    C. amplification
    D. experiment

    Key: A (persuasion)

11. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from paragraph 81: “Here, it will be _____, the words of the narrative run thus:” Word bank: remembered, insoluble, narrative, improvisations

    Key: remembered

12. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from paragraph 75: “I struggled to reason off the _____ which had dominion over me.” Word bank: nervousness, excavation, impromptus, objectless

    Key: nervousness

13. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “a barely perceptible fissure, which, extending from the roof of the building in front, made its way down the wall in a zigzag direction” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 8) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Foreshadowing the collapse.

14. [mc · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage most clearly show? “We have put her living in the tomb” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 92)

    A. Roderick's confession during the storm.

    B. The opening question: a world of storm and repetition.

    C. Her vision of death.

    D. The letter's "new sense."

    Key: A (Roderick's confession during the storm.)

15. [short · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage from paragraph 4 reveal about the character or situation? “It was a mystery all insoluble; nor could I grapple with the shadowy fancies that crowded upon me as I pondered.” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: A response that accurately paraphrases the passage (paragraph 4), cites a specific word or detail from it, and explains its significance.

16. [short · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage from paragraph 79 reveal about the character or situation? “Let us close this casement;—the air is chilling and dangerous to your frame.” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: A response that accurately paraphrases the passage (paragraph 79), cites a specific word or detail from it, and explains its significance.

17. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 73 shapes its tone: “Having deposited our mournful burden upon tressels within this region of horror, we partially turned aside the yet unscrewed lid of the coffin, and looked upon the face of the tenant.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: A response that accurately paraphrases the passage (paragraph 73), cites a specific word or detail from it, and explains its significance.

18. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Connect this passage from paragraph 18 to the story's treatment of the double: “We painted and read together; or I listened, as if in a dream, to the wild improvisations of his speaking guitar.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: A response that accurately paraphrases the passage (paragraph 18), cites a specific word or detail from it, and explains its significance for the double.

19. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What flaw does the narrator notice in the house's front?

    A. A barely visible crack running down the wall

    B. A missing door

    C. A broken window

D. A fallen tower

Key: A (A barely visible crack running down the wall)

20. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 73? "Having _____ our mournful burden upon tressels within this region of horror, we partially turned aside the yet unscrewed lid of the coffin, and looked upon the face of the tenant."

    A. deposited

    B. impromptus

    C. nervousness

    D. experiment

    Key: A (deposited)

21. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "Minute fungi _____ the whole exterior, hanging in a fine tangled web-work from the eaves." Word bank: overspread, unmingled, despaired, equivocal

    Key: overspread

22. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What happens to the house at the end?

    A. It burns down

    B. The narrator inherits it

    C. It splits apart and sinks into the tarn

    D. It is sold

    Key: C (It splits apart and sinks into the tarn)

23. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from paragraph 19: "Among other things, I hold painfully in mind a certain singular perversion and _____ of the wild air of the last waltz of Von Weber." Word bank: unconscious, importunate, remembered, amplification

    Key: amplification

24. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 89? "Having rapidly taken notice of all this, I resumed the _____ of Sir Launcelot, which thus proceeded:"

    A. emaciated

    B. objectless

    C. narrative

    D. proceeding

    Key: C (narrative)

25. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from paragraph 5: "A letter, however, had lately reached me in a distant part of the country—a letter from him—which, in its wildly _____ nature, had admitted of no other than a personal reply." Word bank: emaciated, importunate, persuasion, exaggeration

    Key: importunate

26. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "He _____ me with trepidation and passed on." Word bank: unmingled, accosted, despaired, equivocal

    Key: accosted

27. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "The general furniture was _____, comfortless, antique, and tattered." Word bank: unmingled, equivocal, despaired, profuse

    Key: profuse

28. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 8: “a barely _____ fissure, which, extending from the roof of the building in front, made its way down the wall in a zigzag direction”

    Key: perceptible

29. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from paragraph 74: “He roamed from chamber to chamber with hurried, unequal, and _____ step.” Word bank: objectless, impromptus, emaciated, reminiscences

    Key: objectless

30. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Why does the narrator visit the House of Usher?

    A. He is lost in a storm

    B. Roderick wrote asking for his company

    C. He wants to buy it

    D. He is a doctor called to Madeline

    Key: B (Roderick wrote asking for his company)

31. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from paragraph 4: “I know not how it was—but, with the first glimpse of the building, a sense of _____ gloom pervaded my spirit.” Word bank: insufferable, persuasion, unconscious, excavation

    Key: insufferable

32. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 92: “We have put her _____ in the tomb”

    Key: living

33. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from paragraph 21: “But the fervid facility of his _____ could not be so accounted for.” Word bank: insoluble, reminiscences, perceiving, impromptus

    Key: impromptus

34. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “I feel that the period will sooner or later arrive when I must abandon life and reason together, in some struggle with the grim phantasm, Fear” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 14) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Roderick's prophecy.

35. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 91 shapes its tone: “But, as I placed my hand upon his shoulder, there came a strong shudder over his whole person; a sickly smile quivered about his lips; and I saw that he spoke in a low, hurried, and gibbering murmur, as if unconscious of my presence.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: A response that accurately paraphrases the passage (paragraph 91), cites a specific word or detail from it, and explains its significance.

36. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Fall of the House of Usher”? The house is described like a face: "vacant eye-like windows," decayed stones, a "barely perceptible fissure" running from roof to water. The this device is the story's main character.

    A. Setting

    B. Point of view

    C. Theme

    D. Foreshadowing

    Key: A (Setting)

37. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 11 shapes its tone: “We sat down; and for some moments, while he spoke not, I gazed upon him with a feeling half of pity, half of awe.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: A response that accurately paraphrases the passage (paragraph 11), cites a specific word or detail from it, and explains its significance.

38. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Connect this passage from paragraph 75 to the story's treatment of the double: “I struggled to reason off the nervousness which had dominion over me.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: A response that accurately paraphrases the passage (paragraph 75), cites a specific word or detail from it, and explains its significance for the double.

39. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who is Madeline?

    A. The housekeeper

    B. Roderick's twin sister

    C. Roderick's wife

    D. The narrator's cousin

    Key: B (Roderick's twin sister)

40. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from paragraph 78: “I say that even their exceeding density did not prevent our _____ this—yet we had no glimpse of the moon or stars—nor was there any flashing forth of the lightning.” Word bank: perceiving, moments, improvisations, objectless

    Key: perceiving

41. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 79? “Let us close this casement;—the air is chilling and _____ to your frame.”

    A. exaggeration

    B. dangerous

    C. emaciated

    D. experiment

    Key: B (dangerous)

42. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “The Fall of the House of Usher”?

    A. Courage in defense of home

    B. A family and a house collapsing together

    C. Courage and guilt in a small community

    D. The foolishness of wishing to be young again

    Key: B (A family and a house collapsing together)

43. [short · inference · DOK 2] What does this passage from paragraph 21 reveal about the character or situation? “But the fervid facility of his impromptus could not be so accounted for.” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: A response that accurately paraphrases the passage (paragraph 21), cites a specific word or detail from it, and explains its significance.

44. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “a barely perceptible fissure, which, extending from the roof of the building in front, made its way down the wall in a zigzag direction” (The

Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 8) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

Sample answer: Foreshadowing the collapse.

45. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 20? “Certain accessory points of the design served well to convey the idea that this _____ lay at an exceeding depth below the surface of the earth.”

    A. inexplicable

    B. exaggeration

    C. excavation

    D. unconscious

    Key: C (excavation)

46. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What happens to Madeline that turns out to be terrible?

    A. She is entombed while still alive

    B. She runs away

    C. She burns the house

    D. She marries the narrator

    Key: A (She is entombed while still alive)

47. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “It was, he said, a constitutional and a family evil, and one for which he despaired to find a remedy—a mere nervous affection, he immediately added, which would undoubtedly soon pass off.”, what does “despaired” most nearly mean?

    A. open to two or more interpretations; or of uncertain nature or significance; or (often) intended to mislead

    B. pure; not mixed with anything else

    C. abandon hope; give up hope; lose heart

    D. a feeling of alarm or dread

    Key: C (abandon hope; give up hope; lose heart)

48. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “I learned, moreover, at intervals, and through broken and equivocal hints, another singular feature of his mental condition.”, what does “equivocal” most nearly mean?

    A. a feeling of alarm or dread

    B. open to two or more interpretations; or of uncertain nature or significance; or (often) intended to mislead

    C. pure; not mixed with anything else

    D. abandon hope; give up hope; lose heart

    Key: B (open to two or more interpretations; or of uncertain nature or significance; or (often) intended to mislead)

49. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Fall of the House of Usher”? Sound and light are muffled and dim; inside, Roderick's paintings and music (and the poem "The Haunted Palace") repeat the story's own images.

    A. Imagery

    B. Diction / vocabulary

    C. Foreshadowing

    D. Symbolism

Key: A (Imagery)

50. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
    Sample answer: The narrator notices "a barely perceptible fissure" from roof to ground, and Roderick foresees the day he "must abandon life and reason together"; at the end the fissure widens and house and mind fall at once.

51. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “We have put her living in the tomb” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 92). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
    Sample answer: Roderick's confession during the storm.

52. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 18? “We painted and read together; or I listened, as if in a dream, to the wild _____ of his speaking guitar.”
    A. moments
    B. improvisations
    C. unconscious
    D. persuasion

    Key: B (improvisations)

53. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “He accosted me with trepidation and passed on.”, what does “trepidation” most nearly mean?
    A. pure; not mixed with anything else
    B. open to two or more interpretations; or of uncertain nature or significance; or (often) intended to mislead
    C. abandon hope; give up hope; lose heart
    D. a feeling of alarm or dread

    Key: D (a feeling of alarm or dread)

54. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “I regarded her with an utter astonishment not unmingled with dread—and yet I found it impossible to account for such feelings.”, what does “unmingled” most nearly mean?
    A. a feeling of alarm or dread
    B. open to two or more interpretations; or of uncertain nature or significance; or (often) intended to mislead
    C. pure; not mixed with anything else
    D. abandon hope; give up hope; lose heart

    Key: C (pure; not mixed with anything else)

55. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how fear and the imagination develops from an earlier story to “The Fall of the House of Usher”. Use one quotation from each.
    Sample answer: Roderick says he will "abandon life and reason together" in a struggle with fear; the story makes the reader share the narrator's growing panic.

56. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from paragraph 11: “We sat down; and for some _____, while he spoke not, I gazed upon him with a feeling half of pity, half of awe.” Word bank: perceiving, moments, proceeding, insoluble
    Key: moments

57. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Poe uses the house as a mirror of Roderick's mind, so its collapse completes his. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “a barely perceptible fissure, which, extending from the roof of the building in front, made its way down the wall in a zigzag direction” (The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 8).

    Sample answer: The narrator notices "a barely perceptible fissure" from roof to ground, and Roderick foresees the day he "must abandon life and reason together"; at the end the fissure widens and house and mind fall at once.

58. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Fall of the House of Usher, paragraph 14: “I feel that the period will sooner or later arrive when I must abandon life and reason _____, in some struggle with the grim phantasm, Fear”

    Key: together

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18	recall 12, inference 4, analysis 1, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	19, 11, 20, 2, 21, 22, 10, 23, 9, 24, 25, 26, 6, 27, 28, 13, 14, 18	recall 15, inference 2, analysis 0, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	29, 28, 30, 10, 31, 1, 32, 9, 20, 25, 33, 34, 14, 35, 36, 37, 38, 18	recall 11, inference 2, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	39, 19, 8, 21, 25, 40, 28, 7, 41, 4, 22, 2, 14, 42, 43, 35, 38, 44	recall 12, inference 3, analysis 1, synthesis 2
HS Senior	3, 21, 20, 45, 6, 9, 46, 10, 31, 28, 29, 11, 14, 13, 34, 37, 36, 38	recall 12, inference 3, analysis 2, synthesis 1
AP	26, 4, 46, 39, 47, 31, 48, 5, 2, 12, 22, 14, 16, 13, 43, 34, 49, 50	recall 11, inference 5, analysis 1, synthesis 1
College Freshman	6, 45, 22, 2, 48, 47, 40, 32, 25, 41, 7, 23, 15, 13, 34, 35, 51, 36	recall 12, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 0
College Sophomore	2, 3, 25, 28, 52, 19, 10, 23, 20, 7, 53, 54, 5, 13, 14, 16, 34, 55	recall 13, inference 4, analysis 0, synthesis 1
College Junior	28, 9, 26, 23, 2, 40, 3, 39, 24, 56, 22, 33, 15, 14, 16, 34, 57, 36	recall 12, inference 4, analysis 2, synthesis 0
College Senior	12, 29, 53, 23, 10, 45, 26, 7, 4, 9, 11, 47, 54, 6, 34, 13, 51, 55	recall 14, inference 2, analysis 1, synthesis 1
Graduate / PhD	9, 31, 8, 47, 46, 53, 24, 40, 39, 5, 58, 52, 25, 20, 43, 42, 51, 44	recall 14, inference 2, analysis 1, synthesis 1

Final paper

The Fall of the House of Usher: final paper (formal literary analysis). Choose one prompt.

1. Analyze how Edgar Allan Poe develops decay of family and mind across The Fall of the House of Usher. Trace the idea through at least three moments (beginning, middle and end) and argue what the ending finally suggests.
2. Choose one recurring symbol, image or motif in The Fall of the House of Usher and argue how its meaning changes over the story and why that change matters to fear and the imagination.
3. Analyze a central character's choices in The Fall of the House of Usher. Argue whether the story judges that character, and how its structure or point of view shapes your answer.
4. Two readers disagree about whether The Fall of the House of Usher finally endorses or criticizes its society's view of the double. Weigh both readings and argue for one, answering the strongest objection.

Length: Scaffolded support 500-700 words; HS Freshman 700-900 words; HS Sophomore 900-1,100 words; HS Junior 1,000-1,300 words; HS Senior 1,200-1,500 words; AP 1,300-1,600 words; College Freshman 1,500-2,000 words; College Sophomore 2,000-2,500 words; College Junior 2,500-3,000 words; College Senior 3,000-4,000 words; Graduate / PhD 4,000-6,000 words

Evidence requirement: at least 4 quotations from at least two parts of the story. Quote the reading text exactly and cite the paragraph (MLA style). HS Senior and above: one scholarly or historical source; College Sophomore and above: two, cited in MLA.

Criterion	Points	Descriptor
Thesis	20	A specific, arguable claim that answers the prompt and organizes the paper.
Evidence	25	Well-chosen, accurately quoted and cited passages from across the work, meeting the evidence requirement.
Analysis	30	Explains how language, structure and literary elements create meaning; goes beyond summary.
Organization	15	Logical progression, clear topic sentences and transitions; introduction and conclusion frame the argument.
Style and conventions	10	Formal academic voice, present tense for literature, correct grammar and MLA format.

Essay assignments

Essay: Decay of family and mind

Scaffolded support (600 words; AP: see unit standards): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Fall of the House of Usher teaches about decay of family and mind. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Edgar Allan Poe develops decay of family and mind in The Fall of the House of Usher. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Edgar Allan Poe develops decay of family and mind across The Fall of the House of Usher. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Fall of the House of Usher (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of decay of family and mind. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of decay of family and mind in The Fall of the House of Usher. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Edgar Allan Poe's choices in The Fall of the House of Usher (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of decay of family and mind, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Fall of the House of Usher's treatment of decay of family and mind in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on decay of family and mind in The Fall of the House of Usher that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on decay of family and mind in The Fall of the House of Usher. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about decay of family and mind in The Fall of the House of Usher, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on decay of family and mind in The Fall of the House of Usher, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Fear and the imagination

Scaffolded support (600 words; AP: see unit standards): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Fall of the House of Usher teaches about fear and the imagination. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Edgar Allan Poe develops fear and the imagination in The Fall of the House of Usher. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Edgar Allan Poe develops fear and the imagination across The Fall of the House of Usher. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Fall of the House of Usher (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of fear and the imagination. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of fear and the imagination in The Fall of the House of Usher. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Edgar Allan Poe's choices in The Fall of the House of Usher (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of fear and the imagination, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Fall of the House of Usher's treatment of fear and the imagination in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on fear and the imagination in The Fall of the House of Usher that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on fear and the imagination in The Fall of the House of Usher. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about fear and the imagination in The Fall of the House of Usher, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on fear and the imagination in The Fall of the House of Usher, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: The double

Scaffolded support (600 words; AP: see unit standards): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Fall of the House of Usher teaches about the double. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Edgar Allan Poe develops the double in The Fall of the House of Usher. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Edgar Allan Poe develops the double across The Fall of the House of Usher. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; AP: see unit standards): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Fall of the House of Usher (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of the double. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of the double in The Fall of the House of Usher. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Edgar Allan Poe's choices in The Fall of the House of Usher (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of the double, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Fall of the House of Usher's treatment of the double in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on the double in The Fall of the House of Usher that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on the double in The Fall of the House of Usher. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about the double in The Fall of the House of Usher, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; AP: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on the double in The Fall of the House of Usher, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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